

FAMILY MATTERS

- 90% of depressed teens who respond to treatment have no perception of family discord—parental fights, with other family members or with themselves
- Those who respond well report two hours of extra attention from parents, compared to those who do not
- 52% of those who get better have parents encouraging sport, recreation and other cultural activities
- 46% of depressed teens have pushy and achievement-oriented parents
- 50% of depressed children have parents who control every aspect of their lives

Source: Child & Adolescent Psychiatry Clinic, AIIMS

65%

families don't have any inkling about their children's depression or suicidal thoughts

happiest lot in the world. Globalisation has boosted India's happiness quotient, claimed an MTV world survey. The optimism level of 77 per cent in India is considerably higher than the global average of 36 per cent, cried a McKinsey survey. In yet another HSBC survey, 93 per cent Mumbai elite cited one of the major parameters of happiness as the ability to "send children off to the best schools and colleges abroad".

It's a problem of plenty, say psychologists. Recent studies show that children who have been given too much too soon grow up to be adults who have difficulty coping with

life's disappointments. "They have a distorted sense of entitlement that gets in the way of success both in the workplace and in relationships," says Dr G. Gururaj, head, department of epidemiology at the National Institute of Mental Health (NIMHANS) in Bangalore. "They often grow up to be self-centred and self-absorbed, and those are mental-health risks." India's economic success story has resulted in escalating aspirations. "Young people feel they can achieve anything and want instant gratification. When they don't get it, they become impatient and frustrated," holds Gururaj. A suicide sur-

vey which he conducted in 2004 found that 57 per cent of youth suicides were sudden acts of frustration.

Mehta recalls a mother who had come to visit her after her son had committed suicide. He was a bully: intimidating younger children in school, breaking things at home, hitting the domestic help, yelling at his elders. But the parents got terrified when, in fits of temper, he would issue death threats and browbeat them into giving him whatever he wanted. Finally, one afternoon, he made one more threat and this time succeeded in snuffing out his own life. "The family was sad but a little relieved, too," says Mehta. "They had created a wanting machine and didn't know how to cope with him anymore." Devi Kar, principal of Modern High School, Kolkata, comes across many such pushover parents. "We see

"Despite the extent of knowledge today, signs of distress all too often go unheeded by family members."

G. GURURAJ
EPIDEMIOLOGIST, NIMHANS